



Logged as Watered, Kept Alive by the Corridor

A soil-moisture instrument validated against 14 weeks of informal office-plant care

Sten Okwuosa · Thandiwe Solberg — School of Continuous Improvement

Background

Facilities credits its office-plant watering agent with keeping shared kitchenettes green, scheduling refills from soil-moisture readings alone. Little is known about how often a threshold breach follows a colleague's hand top-up rather than precedes it.

Aims

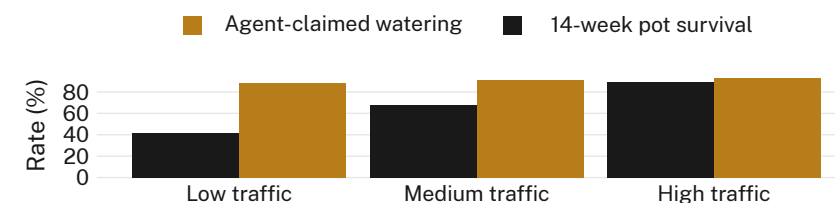
- Validate the agent's soil-moisture reading against directly observed pot condition
- Establish how often a "successful watering" log follows an undocumented hand top-up
- Test whether 14-week survival tracks the agent's schedule or kitchenette foot traffic

Methods

- 58 pots, 11 shared kitchenettes; covert weekly soil-moisture and leaf-turgor checks, 14 weeks (Feb–May 2026)
- Logistic model regressing week-14 survival on agent-logged waterings vs. observed hand top-ups
- Kitchenette foot traffic held constant via building-access swipe counts, tertile-split

Results

Agent-logged watering rates hold flat across kitchenettes; pot survival does not. Two in three logs the agent scores as a successful watering follow an unlogged hand top-up within the previous hour.



Agent-claimed watering held at 88–93% in every traffic tertile; pot survival ranged from 42% (lowest) to 89% (highest) (n = 58 pots, 14 weeks, Feb–May 2026).

Discussion & conclusions

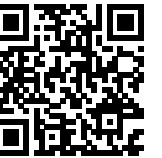
The instrument is consistent; it isn't measuring survival. A flat log against a sliding survival curve points to something outside the sensor's field. Next: instrument the corridor, not the pot.

References

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No plant identifiers retained beyond pot number; kitchenette occupants not tracked. Ethics exemption 2026/019.

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“Two in three ‘successful waterings’ were logged after someone else already did it.”

58 pots · 11 kitchenettes · 14 weeks · Feb–May 2026